

THE HEALING AND GROWTH JOURNAL

Website Design & Development Brief

Prepared for: Website Designer / Developer

Purpose: A complete build guide for the official digital home of The Healing and Growth Journal.

Core positioning: The website should be the digital home of The Healing and Growth Journal, with Substack serving as the publishing, newsletter, and subscriber engine.

1. PROJECT OVERVIEW

The Healing and Growth Journal is a platform dedicated to healing, self-discovery, personal growth, grief support, reflection, emotional wellness, resilience, and becoming the best version of yourself.

The website must feel like a warm, human, thoughtful and trustworthy space—not a generic blog, therapy template, magazine template, or corporate wellness website.

The primary goals are:

1. · Create a strong, searchable home for the brand that can be discovered through Google and other search engines.
2. · Build an owned digital home for the brand rather than making Substack the only home.
3. · Connect readers naturally to the Substack publication and subscription page.
4. · Publish selected evergreen articles and resources on the website.
5. · Create a professional shop for digital products such as journals, journal prompts, guides and future resources.
6. · Give new visitors an easy path to understand the brand, find the right content, subscribe, and eventually purchase resources.
7. · Create a scalable structure that can later support courses, books, professional support, community offerings and other future developments.

2. BRAND FOUNDATION — USE THIS LANGUAGE CAREFULLY

Brand Name: The Healing and Growth Journal

Primary tagline: A safe space to heal, love, and grow.

Brand purpose: A platform dedicated to healing, self-discovery, personal growth, grief support, reflection, emotional wellness, resilience, and becoming the best version of yourself.

Vision: To help people navigate difficult seasons in life without losing themselves.

honest and vulnerable; hopeful without being preachy; deep but easy to understand; like a real person writing from lived experience.

Writing style: Reflective and thoughtful; conversational rather than academic; emotionally intelligent; gentle but powerful; able to move between deep reflection, practical guidance, clear explanations, personal observations, life lessons, poetry, short-form writing and long-form articles.

3. VISUAL DIRECTION

The visual identity should use the existing brand direction: gradient cream, light green and cream, with orange as an accent. The overall appearance should be soft, warm, human and calm.

- Use generous white/cream space and breathing room.
- Use subtle light-green and cream sections with restrained orange accents.
- Typography should feel editorial, elegant and highly readable.
- Use rounded or softly structured elements where appropriate, but avoid an overly playful look.
- Do not make the website look like a generic Substack clone.
- Do not overload pages with graphics, animations or decorative elements.
- The site should feel human-made, intimate and premium without looking expensive or corporate

4. REQUIRED MAIN NAVIGATION

- Home
- About
- Start Here
- The Journal / Articles
- Resources
- Shop
- Substack / Subscribe
- Contact

The navigation should remain simple and visible. On mobile, use a clean mobile menu. The Subscribe/Join the Journal action should be visually prominent without becoming aggressive.

5. HOME PAGE — REQUIRED STRUCTURE

5.1 Hero Section

Headlines should clearly communicate what the journal is. Recommended direction: “A place to heal, love, and grow.”

Supporting copy should briefly explain that The Healing and Growth Journal offers reflections, stories, healing notes and resources for people moving through grief, heartbreak, difficult seasons, life transitions and personal growth.

Primary CTA: “Start Here”

Secondary CTA: “Read the Journal”

A visible Substack subscription CTA should also appear within the home page journey.

5.2 What We Write About

Create four visually distinct content areas:

- Healing — Grief, loss, emotional healing, letting go, disappointment.
- Growth — Life after healing, starting again, identity, becoming.
- Relationships — Love, heartbreak, boundaries, connection, poems.
- Reflection — Personal essays, letters, journal entries, and quiet observations about life.

5.3 Featured / Latest Writing

Show selected recent articles with large, emotionally relevant images, title, short excerpt and a clear Read button.

5.4 Start Here

This section should help a first-time visitor immediately identify where to begin. Each pathway should contain 2 carefully selected articles/resources and a short explanation of why they are relevant.

START HERE PAGE

This should function as the orientation page for first-time visitors.

- Start here if you are grieving.
- Start here if you are healing from heartbreak.
- Start here if you are going through a difficult season.
- Start here if you are starting over.
- Start here if you feel lost or disconnected from yourself.
- Start here if you want to grow intentionally.

5.5 Substack Invitation

Invitation message.....

Primary CTA: “Subscribe on Substack”

5.6 Resources / Shop Preview

Show a small number of featured resources/products and link to the full shop.

5.7 Closing Brand Section

Use a quiet, emotionally resonant closing invitation rather than a loud sales banner. The feeling should be, 'You do not have to figure everything out alone.'

THE JOURNAL / ARTICLES

The website should have a searchable, filterable article library.

Suggested categories/tags:

- Healing (Grief, Loss & Emotional)
- Growth
- Love
- Letters
- Journal Entries/Reflections

Article pages should include: title, featured image, category/tag, publication date, readable body typography, related articles, Substack CTA, and optional resource/product CTA.

The website should support SEO metadata, clean URLs, social sharing, image alt text, canonical URLs where appropriate, XML sitemap, robots.txt, and Google Search Console integration.

SUNDAY LOVE SERIES

The Sunday Love series is a section in our Substack publication where we publish love poems and love-related articles, letters, etc

Subscribe to read

SUBSCRIBE BUTTON HERE

Featured resource ideas

- 31-Day Gentle Healing Journal — A gentle journey for anyone learning to live with what happened and still move forward.
- Journal Prompts for Difficult Seasons — Guided prompts for readers who need language for what they are carrying.

- Healing After Heartbreak Guide — Practical and reflective support for navigating the aftermath of heartbreak.
- The Starting Again Guide — A resource for people rebuilding after change, disappointment or a difficult season.
- Self-Discovery Journal — Prompts designed to help readers understand themselves more deeply.
- Reflection Workbook — Space to pause, process, learn and move forward.

12. SHOP

The Shop should be a dedicated, clean ecommerce area. It must be easy to browse, understand and purchase digital resources.

Each product page should contain: product name, clear description, who it is for, what is included, preview/mockup images where appropriate, price, secure checkout, delivery information, and a clear purchase button.

Initial product direction:

- 31-Day Gentle Healing Journal
- Journal prompt collections
- Easy how-to / practical guides
- E-books
- Reflection workbooks

Future expansion can include courses, audio resources, books and other educational materials.

13. SUBSTACK INTEGRATION

Substack remains a major part of the ecosystem.

- Every major article page should have a natural invitation to subscribe.
- The home page should include a prominent but tasteful Subscribe on Substack section.
- Use direct links to the official Substack publication and subscription page.
- Selected website content can point readers to the full Substack publication.
- Do not make every page feel like an advertisement for Substack; the website must provide standalone value.

Primary publication: The Healing and Growth Journal on Substack.

14. CONTACT PAGE

Keep the Contact page simple and professional. Include a contact form, relevant email/contact details when supplied, and a brief explanation of what visitors can contact the Journal about.

Do not make the page cluttered.

15. IMAGE & ART DIRECTION

Images are extremely important. The website should avoid generic stock photography wherever possible.

The image direction should communicate real human emotion, reflection, healing, quietness, hope and becoming.

- Soft natural light.
- Warm, muted, gentle colour palettes consistent with cream, light green and subtle orange.
- People in thoughtful, natural moments rather than exaggerated smiling or crying stock-photo poses.
- Quiet rooms, windows, pathways, nature, handwritten pages, journals, hands, silhouettes and intimate everyday moments can be used where relevant.
- Use diverse people and situations without making the site feel like a medical or corporate campaign.
- Images should leave emotional space around the subject and work well with text overlays when necessary.
- Use wide hero images for major sections and 1:1 or 4:5 images for cards and social previews.
- Every image must have meaningful alt text for accessibility and SEO.

15.1 Home hero image direction

A quiet, emotionally resonant scene suggesting a person moving through a difficult but hopeful season. Avoid cliché images of someone dramatically crying. The feeling should be reflective, intimate and hopeful.

15.2 Healing imagery

Natural light, solitary reflection, a person near a window, walking outdoors, hands holding a journal, quiet rooms, subtle signs of recovery and calm.

15.3 Growth imagery

Open roads, paths, sunrise/sunset light, someone writing or reflecting, movement forward, plants/new growth, a person standing with quiet confidence.

15.4 Love / Sunday Love Series imagery

Tender but sophisticated imagery: hands, letters, two people in natural connection, quiet intimacy, distance, memory and affection. Avoid overly romantic cliché stock photography.

15.5 Grief imagery

Use restraint. Images should communicate absence, memory, quietness and love rather than dramatizing pain. Avoid funeral clichés wherever possible.

15.6 Product imagery

Create clean digital mockups of journals, guides and workbooks. Use the brand palette and enough whitespace to make the products look premium and trustworthy.

16. RESPONSIVE DESIGN

- The website must be designed mobile-first.
- All pages must work cleanly on mobile, tablet and desktop.
- Navigation must be simple on mobile.
- Text must remain highly readable.
- Buttons must be large enough for touch interaction.
- Images must be optimized for speed without visibly reducing quality.

17. TECHNICAL / SEO REQUIREMENTS

- Fast loading speed and optimized images.
- HTTPS/SSL.
- Responsive design.
- Search-engine-friendly page titles and meta descriptions.
- Clean, human-readable URLs.
- XML sitemap.
- Robots.txt configured correctly.
- Canonical URLs where needed.
- Open Graph/social sharing metadata.
- Schema/structured data where appropriate, especially for articles, products and organization information.
- Google Search Console setup.
- Google Analytics or another privacy-conscious analytics solution.
- Accessible headings and semantic page structure.
- Alt text for meaningful images.
- Easy content management so new articles and products can be added without rebuilding the site.

18. WEBSITE FOOTER

The footer should contain:

- The Healing and Growth Journal logo/name.
- Short brand description.

- Navigation links.
- Substack link.
- Subscribe link.
- Social media links.
- Contact link.
- Privacy Policy.
- Terms and Conditions.
- Refund/return policy where applicable for products.
- Copyright information.

19. CALL-TO-ACTION JOURNEY

The website should guide visitors naturally through this journey:

READ → SUBSCRIBE → DOWNLOAD → BUY → EXPLORE → RETURN

A visitor should never feel trapped or pushed into buying. Every CTA should feel like a useful next step.

20. DESIGN PRINCIPLES — NON-NEGOTIABLE

- Do not make the website look like a generic wellness website.
- Do not overload it with stock photos.
- Do not use aggressive sales language.
- Do not make every section visually identical.
- Do not crowd the pages.
- Do not use too many colours.
- Do not make the website overly clinical.
- Do not make it look like a generic Substack template.
- Do preserve the warmth, vulnerability and emotional intelligence of the brand.
- Do create clear visual separation between sections.
- Do use whitespace generously.
- Do make the website easy for a first-time visitor to understand within seconds.
- Do make the site feel like a real editorial brand with a future beyond a blog.

21. FUTURE-READY STRUCTURE

The architecture should allow future additions without redesigning the whole website.

- Paid digital resources.
- 31-day journals and other guided journals.
- Courses.
- Personalized support / conversation offerings.
- Personalized schedule design.
- Books and publishing projects.

- Community initiatives.
- Future professional services.
- Potential Healing Institute / broader educational platform.

Stay With Us

If something you've read here feels familiar, you don't have to leave it behind when you close this page.

Subscribe to The Healing and Growth Journal and receive new reflections, healing notes, poems, practical guidance, journal prompts, and thoughtful resources delivered to you.

Some will help you understand what you are feeling.

Some will give you words for what you could not explain.

Some will challenge you to grow.

And some may simply remind you that you are not alone.

Come as you are. Stay for the journey.

[**Subscribe to The Healing and Growth Journal**]

A place to heal, love, and grow.

JOURNAL PROMPT / SEO CONTENT LIBRARY

The website should contain individual evergreen pages built around specific questions readers are likely to search. These should not be generic keyword pages. Each page should answer a real emotional question with useful, compassionate writing and then point readers toward relevant Journal articles, prompts and products.

Gentle Journal Prompts for When You're Grieving

A soft collection of prompts for people who are carrying loss and need a safe place to put their thoughts, memories, questions and emotions into words.

How Do I Start Over After a Breakup?

A reflective guide for anyone trying to rebuild their sense of self, routine and hope after a relationship ends.

Why Do I Feel Guilty After Someone Dies?

A compassionate exploration of grief-related guilt and the difficult questions people sometimes carry after losing someone they love.

Journal Prompts for When You Feel Lost

Prompts designed to help you slow down, listen to yourself and begin understanding what you need next.

Journal Prompts for Starting Over

Gentle questions for people entering a new chapter after disappointment, loss, change or uncertainty.

How Do I Know If I Am Healing?

A reflective guide to the quieter signs of emotional healing that may be easy to miss.

Journal Prompts for Healing From Heartbreak

Questions to help you process what happened without rushing yourself into pretending you are okay.

What Do I Do When I Miss Someone I Cannot Have Back?

A compassionate reflection on longing, memory, acceptance and learning to carry love without remaining trapped in the past.

Journal Prompts for Self-Discovery

Questions that help readers explore identity, values, fears, desires, boundaries and the person they are becoming.

What If I Don't Recognize Myself Anymore?

A reflective resource for people who feel changed by grief, heartbreak, disappointment or a major life transition.

About The Healing and Growth Journal

A place to heal, love, and grow.

Life can change in a moment.

Sometimes through loss. Sometimes through heartbreak. Sometimes through disappointment, a difficult transition, a relationship that no longer feels the same, or simply the realization that the person you have become is not the person you once imagined you would be.

And sometimes, nothing dramatic has happened at all. You simply know that something inside you needs attention.

The Healing and Growth Journal was created for those moments.

It is a space for honest reflection, meaningful guidance, and thoughtful resources for people learning how to navigate difficult seasons, understand themselves more deeply, heal from what has hurt them, and grow into who they are becoming.

You do not have to have everything figured out to begin.

Why The Journal Began

Hi, I'm **Glory**.

I'm a counselling psychologist, teacher, writer, and the person behind The Healing and Growth Journal.

On **March 19, 2025**, I lost my father — just two days before my convocation.

I had imagined that season differently.

There should have been celebration, photographs, family, laughter, and the joy of reaching a milestone I had worked so hard for.

Instead, grief arrived.

And grief changed me.

It taught me that healing is rarely as straightforward as we imagine it to be. Sometimes you think you have healed until a voice, a memory, a familiar place, or someone else's pain touches a wound you thought had already closed.

I experienced this when a friend sent me a voice note crying about the loss of her own father.

I found myself crying too.

Not only for her, but for the parts of my own grief I had not finished meeting.

That moment reminded me of something I have come to understand deeply:

Healing is not always about moving on. Sometimes, it is about learning how to carry what changed you.

The Healing and Growth Journal grew from that understanding.

But it also grew from something beyond my own grief — from sitting with other people in their pain. Their tears. Their fears. Their questions. The things they could not always say out loud.

I began to see how much people need a place where they can be honest about what they are carrying without being rushed to “get over it.”

And that is what I wanted to create.

What We Believe

At The Healing and Growth Journal, we believe that healing and growth are deeply connected.

You can heal from something and still have more growing to do.

You can grow through an experience without pretending that it did not hurt.

You can love someone and still need boundaries.

You can miss someone and still learn to live without them.

You can be grateful for your life and still admit that some parts of it are difficult.

You can start again without having all the answers.

There is room for complexity here.

We are not interested in telling people to simply “stay positive” when life hurts.

There are moments when you need encouragement.

There are moments when you need truth.

There are moments when you need practical guidance.

And there are moments when you simply need someone to say,

“What you are feeling deserves to be understood.”

This Journal makes room for all of that.

What You’ll Find Here

The Healing and Growth Journal explores the experiences that shape us and the questions that often stay with us long after everyone else has moved on.

Healing

Grief and loss, emotional healing, disappointment, letting go, self-compassion, difficult seasons, and learning to live with what has changed.

Growth

Self-awareness, identity, confidence, purpose, personal development, becoming, and understanding the person you are growing into.

Love & Relationships

Love, heartbreak, friendship, boundaries, connection, communication, and the complicated ways relationships can shape us.

Reflection

Thoughtful observations, personal reflections, letters, poems, questions, and lessons that help us pause long enough to understand ourselves.

Practical Guidance

Resources, journal prompts, guides, and gentle tools designed to help you do more than simply read about healing — but actually begin working through what you are experiencing.

Some days, you may come here looking for words.

Other days, you may come looking for an answer.

Sometimes, you may simply need to know that someone else understands.

There is space for all three.

Who Is Behind The Journal?

I do not write from a place of having life completely figured out.

I'm learning too.

My background in counselling psychology influences the way I think about healing, relationships, emotions, and human behaviour. My experiences have also taught me that understanding something intellectually does not always make living through it easy.

There is a difference between knowing what healing looks like on paper and discovering what it asks of you personally.

That is why I want this space to feel **human**.

Not clinical.

Not judgmental.

Not like a place where you are expected to arrive with the right answers.

I want The Healing and Growth Journal to feel like a thoughtful conversation — one that gives you room to think, feel, question, learn, and take your next step.

When professional guidance is helpful, it should be available.

When a practical tool can make something easier, I want to provide it.

When a reflection can help you put words to something you have struggled to explain, I want to write it.

And when something is beyond what words on a page can hold, I believe there should be room to acknowledge that too.

More Than Something You Read

The Healing and Growth Journal is not simply a place to consume words.

It is being built as a **compassionate community and a growing collection of resources** for people navigating real life.

Here, you will find writing that helps you pause and reflect, practical resources that help you take action, and gentle tools that give you somewhere to begin.

Over time, that will continue to grow — through journals, prompts, practical guides, books, courses, conversations, and other resources created to support healing and intentional growth.

The goal is not to tell you who you should become.

It is to help you understand yourself well enough to make that journey consciously.

If You Found Your Way Here

Maybe you are grieving.

Maybe you are trying to make sense of a relationship that changed you.

Maybe you are starting over.

Maybe you are tired of pretending that you are okay.

Maybe you are doing well, but you know there is still more of yourself you want to understand.

Or maybe you simply believe that life can be lived with greater intention, deeper self-awareness, and more compassion.

Wherever you are, you are welcome here.

You do not have to wait until you fall apart before you begin paying attention to yourself.

You can begin now.

You can ask the difficult question now.

You can learn something new about yourself now.

You can seek help when you need it.

You can begin again.

And you can grow without abandoning the person you have been.

Because healing may not return you to who you were before.

Sometimes, healing introduces you to the person you are becoming.

That is the heart of **The Healing and Growth Journal**.

A place to heal.

A place to love.

A place to grow.

And a place to remember that you do not have to walk through every season alone.

With all my love,

The Healing and Growth Journal